



New labor system

A sharecropper surveys a field of cotton, the most common crop to be grown under the sharecropping system. When cotton prices dropped, sharecroppers' incomes were meager.

Building Black communities

Although racism and discrimination remained, Reconstruction brought many changes to everyday life. The significant social transformations that took place appear all the greater when compared with the hardships of slavery. Slave marriages were not legally binding, and families could be separated through sale. In freedom, former slaves married and labored to reunite lost family members. Black families tried to turn the ideal of the bread-winning father, home-making wife, and properly schooled children into reality.

Newly founded churches played crucial roles in the community. Formal Black churches had been uncommon under slavery, while in white churches, sermons described slavery as worthwhile and godly.